# IMPORTANT CITIES OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

**Grade 8 Social Studies | Notes + Comparative Table + Practice Questions**

## 1. QUICK REVISION NOTES

### 1. LONDON – Capital of the United Kingdom & England

- Situated on the **River Thames** in southeastern England.
- One of the world's preeminent cities – hub of political, economic and cultural network.
- Metropolitan area covers much of southeastern England.
- Continues to serve as the **financial centre of Europe** and a **centre of innovation**.
- Major influence in popular culture worldwide.

### 2. BIRMINGHAM – West Midlands, England

- Major city of the **West Midlands**, lying on the **River Rea**.
- **Largest and most populous** British city outside London.
- Was a medium-sized market town in the medieval period; grew to international prominence in the **18th century**.
- At the heart of the **Industrial Revolution** – advances in science, technology & economic development.
- The **industrial steam engine** (one of the most important inventions in British history) was invented here.
- **Birmingham Hippodrome** is the UK's busiest theatre (over 520,000 visitors each year).

### 3. BELFAST – Capital of Northern Ireland

- Capital and **largest city of Northern Ireland**; second largest city on the island of Ireland.
- Situated on the **River Lagan**; population about **286,000** (2011 census).
- Historic industries: Irish linen, tobacco processing, rope-making and **shipbuilding**.
- **Harland and Wolff** shipyard built the **RMS Titanic** – once the world's biggest and most productive shipyard.
- Key role in the Industrial Revolution; global industrial centre until the latter half of the 20th century.
- Sustained major **aerospace and missiles industry** since the mid-1930s.
- Today: centre for industry, arts, higher education, business and law – the **economic engine of Northern Ireland**.
- Home to the **Titanic Belfast** interactive museum.

### 4. EDINBURGH – Capital of Scotland

- Capital city of Scotland; Scotland's **second most populous** city and the **seventh most populous** in the UK.
- Home to the **Scottish Parliament** and the **seat of the monarchy** in Scotland.
- **Second largest financial centre** in the UK after London.
- Centre of banking for over 300 years: **Bank of Scotland** founded in **1695** (HQ in Edinburgh).
- **Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS)** has its global headquarters in Edinburgh.
- Tourism is a major mainstay: supports **30,000 jobs** worth **£1.6 billion** to the city economy.
- Famous for its stunning mix of architecture: medieval tenements, Old Town, cobbled wynds and Georgian-era buildings.

### 5. CARDIFF – Capital of Wales

- Capital and largest city in Wales; the **eleventh-largest** city in the United Kingdom.
- Country's chief commercial centre; base for national cultural & sporting institutions, Welsh national media.
- Seat of the **National Assembly for Wales** (Senedd).
- Was a small town until the early 19th century; rose as a major port for **coal transport**.
- Became the world's most important **coal port** (handled more than London and Liverpool).
- Made a city in **1905**; proclaimed **capital of Wales in 1955**.
- Main engine of growth in the Welsh economy; centre for white-collar professions.

- Relies principally on **retail, finance, media and tourism** sectors.
- Home to the **Wales Millennium Centre** – a thriving creative capital with rich cultural heritage.

***MEMORY TIP:*** *Remember the order – **L**ondon (England) → **B**irmingham (England) → **B**elfast (N. Ireland) → **E**dinburgh (Scotland) → **C**ardiff (Wales). Think: "**L**arge **B**ritish **B**uildings **E**xcel in **C**ulture!"*

## 2. COMPARATIVE TABLE – EASY TO REMEMBER

| Feature | London | Birmingham | Belfast | Edinburgh | Cardiff |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Country / Region** | England (UK Capital) | West Midlands, England | Northern Ireland | Scotland | Wales |
| **Status** | Capital of UK & England | Largest city outside London | Capital of N. Ireland | Capital of Scotland | Capital of Wales |
| **River** | River Thames | River Rea | River Lagan | — | — |
| **Population Rank** | Largest in UK | 2nd largest in UK (outside London) | Largest in N. Ireland; 2nd on Ireland island | 2nd in Scotland; 7th in UK | Largest in Wales; 11th in UK |
| **Key Historical Role** | Political, economic & cultural hub | Heart of Industrial Revolution; steam engine | Shipbuilding (Titanic); Industrial Revolution | Banking centre since 1695 | World's top coal port in 19th century |
| **Famous Landmark / Fact** | Financial centre of Europe | Birmingham Hippodrome (busiest theatre) | Titanic Belfast Museum; Harland & Wolff | Scottish Parliament; RBS HQ | Wales Millennium Centre; Capital since 1955 |
| **Modern Economy** | Finance, innovation, culture | Industry, technology, culture | Industry, aerospace, arts, education | Finance, banking, tourism (£1.6 bn) | Retail, finance, media, tourism |
| **Special Note** | Metropolitan area covers SE England | Grew to prominence in 18th century | Pop. ~286,000 (2011); economic engine of NI | Tourism: 30,000 jobs | Made city 1905; capital 1955 |

**Quick Comparison Snapshot (One-Line Memory)**

- **London** = Political + Financial Powerhouse (Thames)
- **Birmingham** = Industrial Revolution Heart (Steam Engine + Hippodrome)
- **Belfast** = Shipbuilding & Titanic (Lagan + Harland & Wolff)
- **Edinburgh** = Banking Capital of Scotland (Parliament + RBS)
- **Cardiff** = Coal Port turned Creative Capital (1955 Capital + Millennium Centre)

## 3. PRACTICE QUESTIONS

**A. Fill in the Blanks** (1 mark each)

1. London is situated on the tidal _____ in southeastern England.
2. Birmingham is a major city of the _____, England.
3. The industrial _____ was invented in Birmingham.
4. Belfast is situated on the River _____.
5. Harland and Wolff shipyard in Belfast built the famous ship _____.
6. Edinburgh is the _____ largest financial centre in the UK after London.
7. The Bank of Scotland was founded in the year _____.
8. Cardiff was proclaimed the capital of Wales in the year _____.
9. Birmingham Hippodrome is the UK's _____ theatre with over 520,000 visitors each year.
10. Cardiff relies principally on the retail, finance, media and _____ sectors.

**B. Answer in One Sentence** (1 mark each)

1. Name the capital city of Northern Ireland.
2. Which river flows through Birmingham?
3. What is the population of Belfast according to the 2011 census?
4. Name the interactive museum in Belfast that pays homage to the Titanic.
5. Which city is home to the Scottish Parliament?
6. When was Cardiff made a city?
7. What was Cardiff famous for as a port in the 19th century?
8. Name the busiest theatre in the UK located in Birmingham.
9. Which bank has its global headquarters in Edinburgh?
10. What is the rank of Cardiff among UK cities by population?

**C. Short Answer Questions** (2 marks each)

1. Why is London considered one of the world's preeminent cities?
2. Describe the importance of Birmingham during the Industrial Revolution.
3. What role did Harland and Wolff play in Belfast's industrial history?
4. Explain why Edinburgh is an important financial centre.
5. How did Cardiff rise from a small town to become the capital of Wales?
6. Compare the economic activities of Edinburgh and Cardiff today.
7. State any two facts that show Belfast's importance in the Industrial Revolution and later years.
8. Mention two unique features of Edinburgh's cultural and political importance.

## 4. ANSWER KEY

### A. Fill in the Blanks – Answers

1. River Thames
2. West Midlands
3. steam engine (industrial steam engine)
4. Lagan
5. RMS Titanic
6. second
7. 1695
8. 1955
9. busiest
10. tourism

### B. One Sentence Answers

1. Belfast is the capital city of Northern Ireland.
2. The River Rea flows through Birmingham.
3. The population of Belfast was about 286,000 according to the 2011 census.
4. The Titanic Belfast is the interactive museum that pays homage to the Titanic.
5. Edinburgh is home to the Scottish Parliament.
6. Cardiff was made a city in 1905.
7. Cardiff was the world's most important coal port in the 19th century.
8. Birmingham Hippodrome is the busiest theatre in the UK.
9. The Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS) has its global headquarters in Edinburgh.
10. Cardiff is the eleventh-largest city in the United Kingdom.

### C. Short Answer Questions – Model Answers

**1. Why is London considered one of the world's preeminent cities?**

London is the capital of the UK, situated on the River Thames. It is the hub of a political, economic and cultural network that extends far beyond England's shores. It remains the financial centre of Europe and a major centre of innovation and popular culture.

**2. Describe the importance of Birmingham during the Industrial Revolution.**

Birmingham was at the forefront of the Industrial Revolution. It produced worldwide advances in science, technology and economic development. The industrial steam engine, one of the most important inventions in British history, was invented in Birmingham.

**3. What role did Harland and Wolff play in Belfast's industrial history?**

Harland and Wolff was the world's biggest and most productive shipyard in the early 20th century. It built the famous RMS Titanic and made Belfast a global centre of shipbuilding during the Industrial Revolution.

**4. Explain why Edinburgh is an important financial centre.**

Edinburgh is the second largest financial centre in the UK after London. It has been a centre of banking for over 300 years. The Bank of Scotland was founded there in 1695 and the Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS) has its global headquarters in Edinburgh.

**5. How did Cardiff rise from a small town to become the capital of Wales?**

Cardiff was a small town until the early 19th century. It became a major port for coal transport and grew into the world's most important coal port. It was made a city in 1905 and was proclaimed the capital of Wales in 1955.

**6. Compare the economic activities of Edinburgh and Cardiff today.**

Edinburgh's economy is driven by finance, banking and tourism (supporting 30,000 jobs worth £1.6 billion). Cardiff relies principally on retail, finance, media and tourism sectors and is a centre for white-collar professions and creative industries.

**7. State any two facts that show Belfast's importance in the Industrial Revolution and later years.**

1) Belfast was a global industrial centre with major shipbuilding (Harland & Wolff / Titanic). 2) It has sustained a major aerospace and missiles industry since the mid-1930s and remains the economic engine of Northern Ireland.

8. **Mention two unique features of Edinburgh's cultural and political importance.**

   1) Edinburgh is home to the Scottish Parliament and is the seat of the monarchy in Scotland. 2) It is famous for its stunning mix of medieval, Old Town and Georgian architecture and is a major tourist destination.

***Study Tip for Grade 8:*** *Make a simple mind-map with the 5 cities in a circle. Write the river, one famous fact and the capital status for each. Revise the comparative table daily for 5 minutes – you will remember everything easily!*